

POLAND

ECONOMIC INCLUSION AND LIVELIHOODS OF REFUGEES FROM UKRAINE

OCTOBER-DECEMBER 2024



IOM
UN MIGRATION

GLOBAL DATA INSTITUTE
DISPLACEMENT
TRACKING MATRIX

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International Organization for Migration

Country Office Poland

Wiejska 12 str., Warsaw, Poland

+48 22 538 91 03

Website: <https://dtm.iom.int/poland>

Contact: IOMPolandDRU@iom.int

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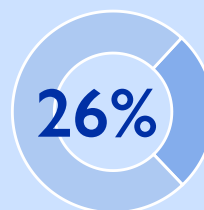
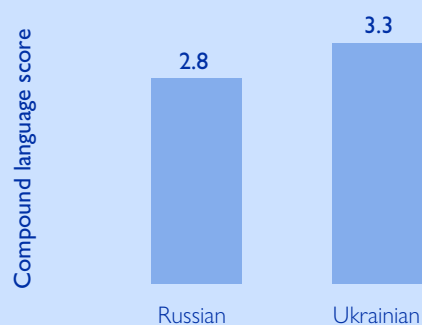
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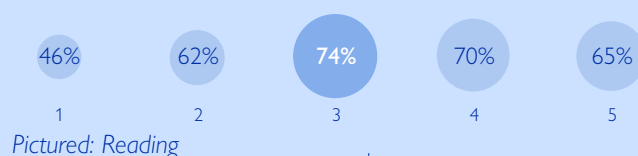
KEY FINDINGS

Russian speakers rated their Polish language proficiency lower than Ukrainian speakers

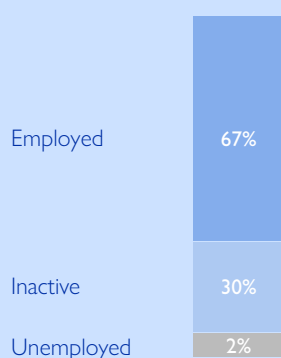


of Russian speakers experienced language-related discrimination

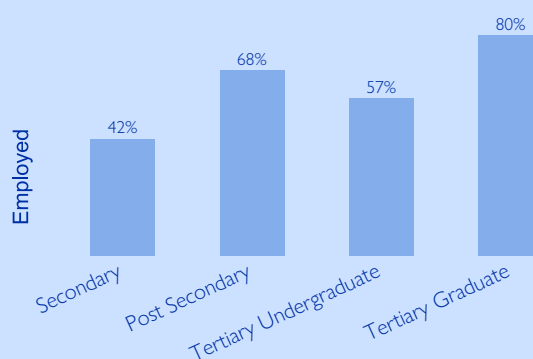
Intermediate self-assessed Polish skills (level 3) mark a threshold for higher employment



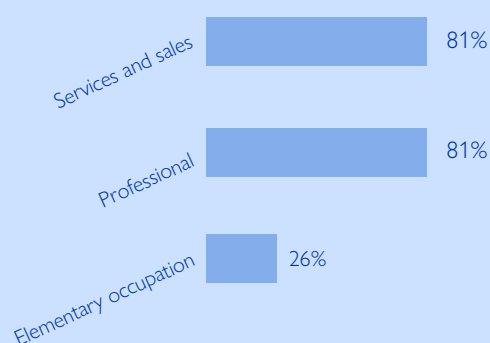
Employment status*



Employment rate by highest level of education completed



Job satisfaction by employment sector



Ability to cover an unexpected expense of 100 euros



Respondents who reported sending money to Ukraine within the past 30 days



*Employment figures include underemployment. Survey conducted in areas with employment levels higher than the national average.

INTRODUCTION

Since 2023, IOM's Displacement Tracking Matrix (DTM) has been collecting data through [Surveys with Refugees in the Ukraine Response Region](#) to assess the progress and needs related to the economic and social integration of refugees from Ukraine. The survey aims to capture insights into employment, housing, financial well-being, social connections, integration challenges, urgent needs, and vulnerabilities, as well as how these factors have evolved over time. A total of 372 surveys were collected between 1 October and 13 December 2024. This report uses multiple indicators – employment status, income levels, language skills, and remittance behaviour – to analyse how Ukrainian refugees are navigating economic inclusion in Poland, and how demographic, geographic, and social factors shape this process. Data analysis used Spearman's rank, Kendall's rank, and Pearson's correlation coefficients.

Of the 372 surveys conducted, 111 (30%) took place in Warsaw, 80 (22%) in Gdańsk, 64 (17%) in Bydgoszcz, 52 (14%) in Przemyśl, 27 (7%) in Kraków, 22 (6%) in Toruń, and the remaining 5 (1%) in other locations. Results are rounded to the nearest whole number and some questions allow multiple answers; hence, some totals may fall below or above 100 per cent.

It is worth noting that the cities where the survey was conducted generally have higher employment rates among the local Polish population compared to the national average. This should be taken into account when interpreting the findings.

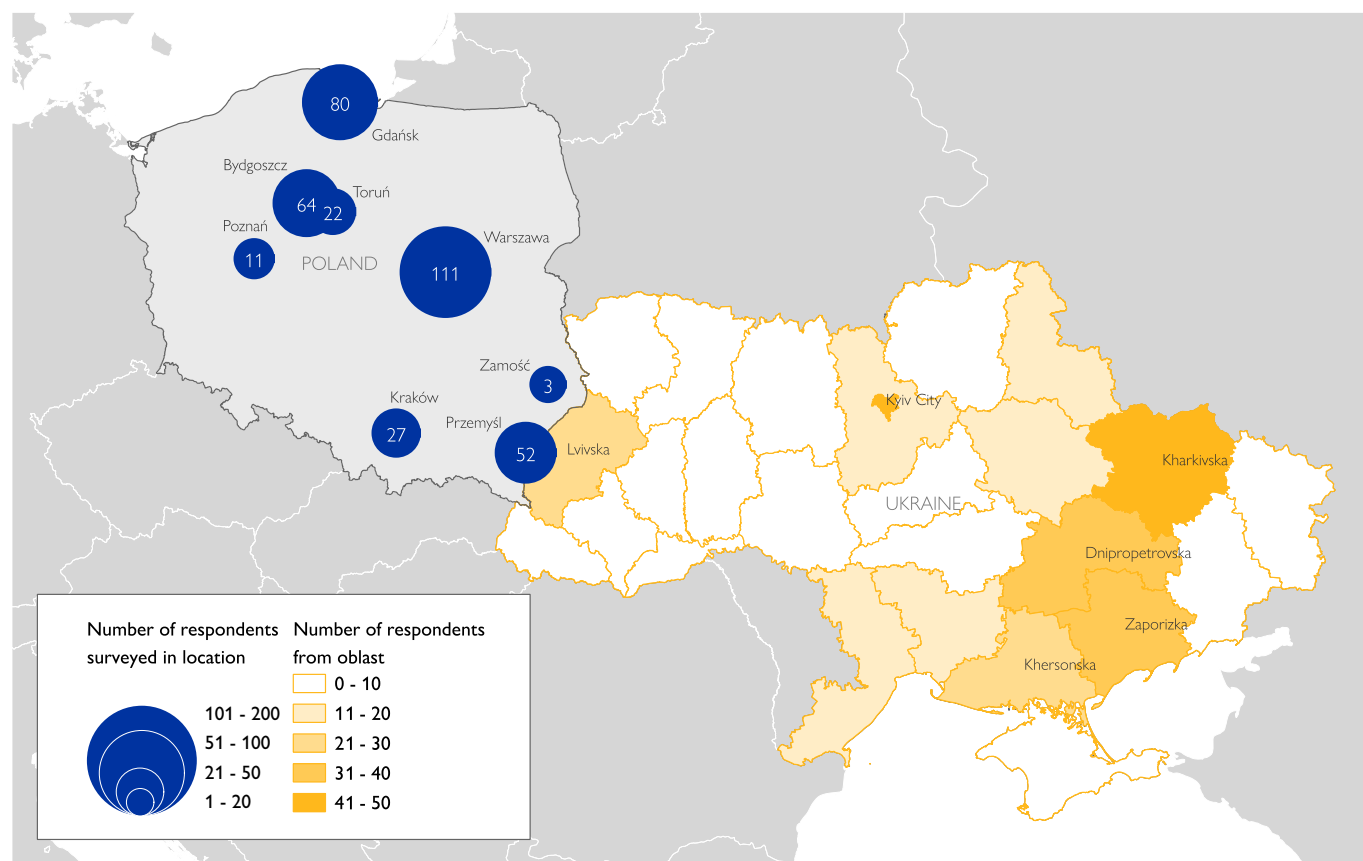
SAMPLE DEMOGRAPHICS

Female respondents made up 92 per cent of the sample, while male respondents accounted for 7 per cent, and fewer than 1 per cent selected "other." In terms of age, 36 per cent of respondents were between 18 and 34 years old, 55 per cent were between 35 and 60, and the remaining 9 per cent were over 60.

More than half of the respondents (57 per cent) reported having children under their care. One in five (19 per cent) were caring for infants, while 11 per cent had persons over 60 in their household. Additionally, 19 per cent reported having at least one type of minor disability. The average reported household size was 2.7.

These demographic characteristics suggest that the sample lacks representativeness (see the [Limitations](#) section).

MAP 1: NUMBER OF SURVEY RESPONDENTS IN LOCATIONS AND FROM OBLASTS, n=370



This map is for illustration purposes only. Names and boundaries on this map do not imply official endorsement or acceptance by IOM.

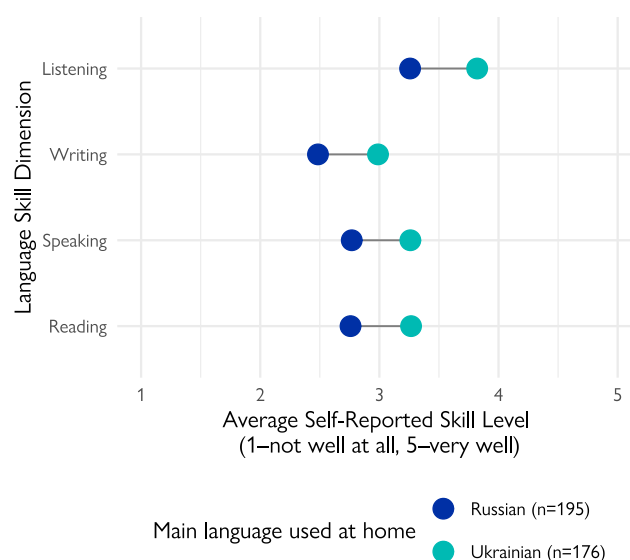
LANGUAGE SKILLS

Respondents were asked to assess their Polish language skills in reading, speaking, writing, and understanding speech on a five-point scale, ranging from not well at all (1) to very well (5). On average, the highest self-assessed language skill was understanding speech (with an average score of 4.5, $n=367$), with 15 per cent of respondents stating they understood speech very well. In contrast, writing was the lowest-rated skill, with an average score of 3.8 ($n=358$). Notably, 15 per cent of respondents reported that they could not write well at all. Reading and speaking received similar average scores of 4.0 ($n=362$ and $n=364$, respectively).

A consistent difference in self-assessed language skills was observed between respondents whose primary language at home was Russian (52%) and those who primarily spoke Ukrainian (47%). Russian-speaking respondents consistently rated their skills 0.5 points lower than their Ukrainian-speaking counterparts (see Figure 1), with compound scores respectively 2.8 and 3.3. This disparity was not influenced by language course attendance, as both Russian- and Ukrainian-speaking respondents participated in courses at a similar rate (69%). It is important to note that this difference pertains only to the primary language spoken at home, as most respondents reported at least some knowledge of the other language. Approximately one in three respondents (31%) cited language courses as a primary need, with a marginally higher percentage of Russian speakers (33%) than Ukrainian speakers (28%). These findings suggest that at least some language courses should be tailored specifically for Russian speakers.

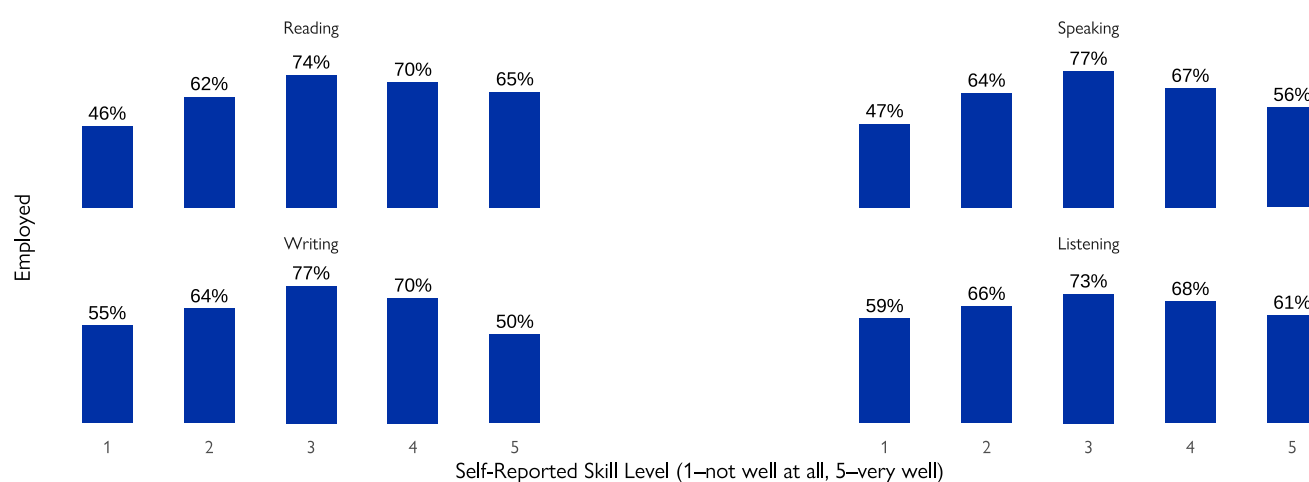
Additionally, 45 per cent of respondents identified the language barrier as a major challenge to inclusion, with a higher proportion of Russian speakers (48%) reporting it as a barrier compared to Ukrainian speakers (43%). Furthermore, 26 per cent of Russian-speaking respondents who experienced discrimination in the host country ($n=53$) reported that the incident was language-related, compared to 15 per cent of Ukrainian speakers ($n=41$).

Figure 1. Average Polish language skill by dimension and main language used at home (Russian, $n=195$, Ukrainian, $n=176$).



Although language skills alone do not show a direct correlation with employment status, there appears to be a threshold level above which employment becomes more common. Respondents who self-rated their skills as intermediate (level 3) were the most frequently employed – this pattern held across all four assessed language dimensions (see: Figure 2). When aggregated into a composite score (i.e., the sum of all four dimensions), language proficiency showed a modest correlation with raw disposable household income. Among the individual language skills, speaking ability exhibited the strongest correlation with income. Notably, although Russian-speaking respondents reported lower average language proficiency than Ukrainian-speaking respondents, their employment rate was higher: 72 per cent ($n=195$) compared to 63 per cent ($n=176$), respectively.

Figure 2. Percentage of employed respondents by Polish language skill level ($n=358$)

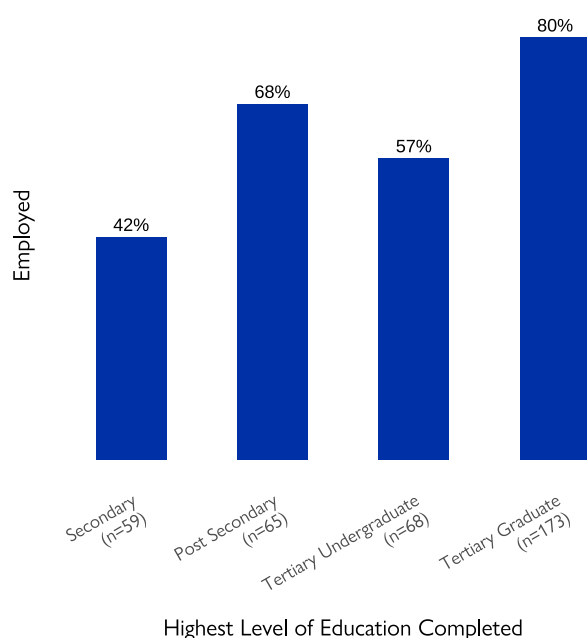


EMPLOYMENT

When considering only respondents of working age, those 18 and older – up to 59 for women and 64 for men, in accordance with the gender-differentiated retirement age – 67 per cent of respondents were employed in some capacity, 30 per cent were inactive, and 2 per cent were unemployed and actively seeking work.¹ While this employment rate is higher than the national average of 57 per cent in 2024, it is important to note that the survey was primarily conducted in locations where employment rates among Polish nationals tend to be above average.

Employment status varied significantly across groups with different levels of educational attainment. Graduates of tertiary education (n=183) had the highest employment rate, at 80 per cent, followed by those who completed other post-secondary education (n=65), with 68 per cent employed. Among current tertiary students (n=173), 57 per cent were employed. Secondary school graduates had an overall employment rate of 42 per cent (n=59), though this varied by level: those who completed upper secondary education (n=35) had a higher employment rate (54%) than lower secondary graduates (25%, n=24). Secondary graduates also had a high level of economic inactivity, at 51 per cent.

Figure 3. Percentage of employed respondents by educational attainment



Only those with sample size above 50 are pictured: Secondary Lower and Secondary Upper are pictured together.

Among the 244 working individuals surveyed, 33 per cent worked as service or sales workers, 22 per cent as professionals, 14 per cent as elementary occupation workers, 8 per cent as clerical support workers, and 5 per cent as managers.

“

I was not hired because they said I had typical Ukrainian looks.

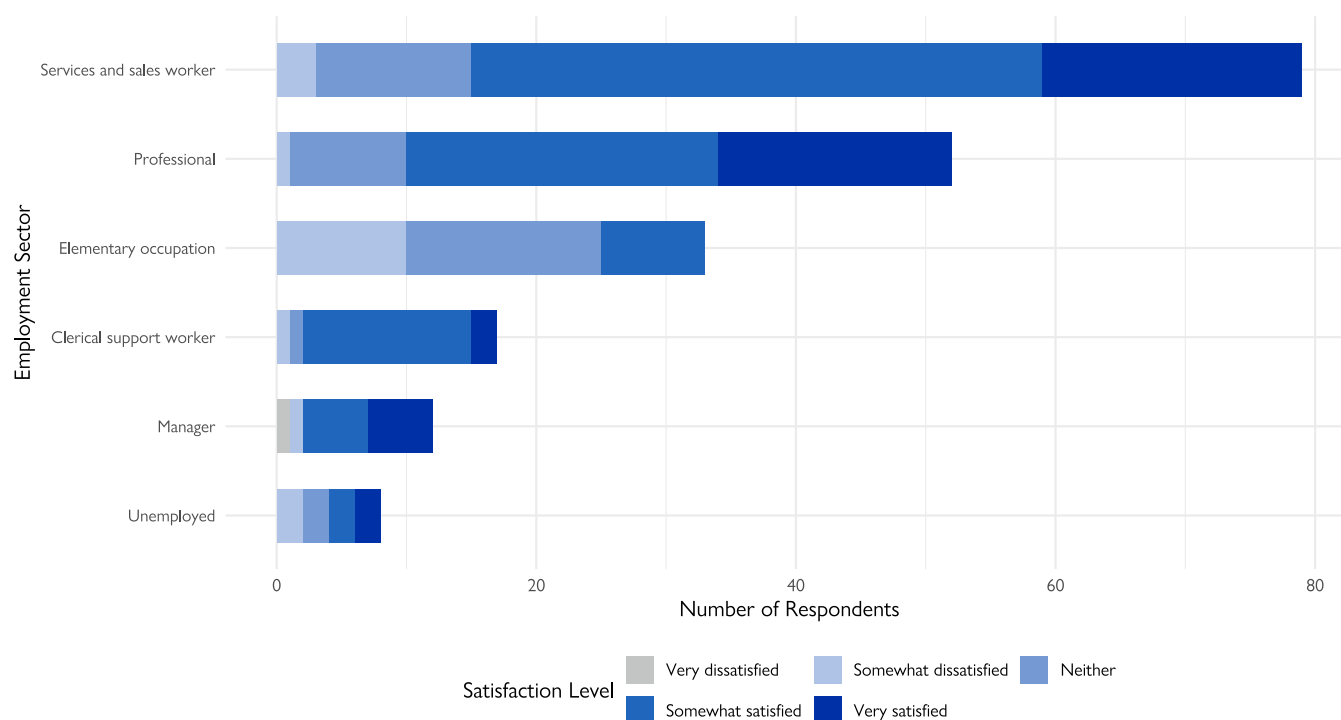
Nineteen-year-old woman, originally from Lvivska oblast

”

The vast majority of professionals and managers were employed in roles that matched their trade profession, with 83 per cent (44 out of 53) of professionals and all 12 managers working within their field. In contrast, 35 per cent (28 out of 80) of services and sales workers (n=80), 58 per cent (11 out of 19) of clerical support workers (n=19), and 91 per cent (32 out of 35) of elementary occupation workers (n=35) were employed outside their trade profession.

A significant proportion of both service and sales workers (35%, 28 out of 80) and elementary occupation workers (27 out of 35) reported their highest level of education as post-secondary or lower. For comparison, this was true for only 3 out of 35 of professionals and 2 out of 19 of clerical support workers. This could suggest that elementary occupations and services and sales roles are more common career choices for refugees whose highest educational attainment is post-secondary or lower.

1. An inter-agency study, [the Socio-economic Insights Survey \(SEIS\)](#), in 2025 indicate that 76 per cent of individuals in this age bracket were employed. This should be considered when interpreting the employment results presented below.

Figure 4. Satisfaction with current employment status by employment sector (number of respondents)

Only those with a sample size above 10 and those who are unemployed are pictured in the above graph.

Around one third (11 out of 35) of elementary occupation workers (n=35) reported dissatisfaction with their employment, while 15 respondents felt neutral, and only 9 expressed satisfaction.

In contrast, 81 per cent (65 out of 80) of services and sales workers (n=80) reported being at least mostly satisfied with their occupation. Similarly, among professionals (n=53), 81 per cent (43 out of 53) expressed satisfaction with their roles. This may suggest that, for individuals whose highest completed educational level is post-secondary and who need to change careers in their country of residence, a services and sales role could be a more satisfying choice than an elementary occupation.

Among parents who were employed (n=155), access to schools were significantly less frequently reported as a challenge (8%), than those inactive (13%, n=62), or unemployed (one in five, n=5). Neither time spent in Poland (on average 782 days), nor previous connections to Poland were associated with employment status.

Among all respondents, 29 per cent identified a lack of job opportunities as a barrier to inclusion. Of the 24 per cent who reported having personally experienced discrimination, a significant number indicated that these incidents occurred in the workplace or during the recruitment process.

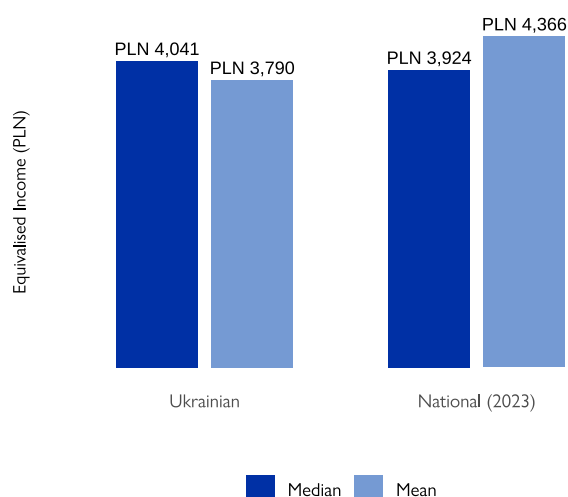
FINANCIAL FLOWS

EQUIVALISED INCOME

The equivalised disposable income² was calculated using the modified OECD equivalence scale, where the net income is divided by the square root of the household size. Approximately half of the respondents provided information about their income, resulting in a sample size of 188. The gender and age distribution of this subsample closely mirrored that of the overall sample: 93 per cent were women, 36 per cent were under 35 years old, 55 per cent were between 35 and 59 years old, and 9 per cent were 60 years or older.

Among the respondents who reported their income, the median equivalised disposable income was PLN 4,041 (EUR 937), and the mean was PLN 3,790 (EUR 878). This means that the equivalised income distribution for Ukrainian respondents is left-skewed, which contrasts with the general pattern observed in the Polish population (see: Figure 5). When compared to the equivalised disposable income of the general Polish population – as reported by Statistics Poland in the 2023 EU-SILC survey³ – the median income of Ukrainian respondents was higher (PLN 3,924 for the Polish population, or EUR 909). However, the mean income of the Polish population (PLN 4,366, EUR 1,012) was higher than that of the Ukrainian respondents.

Figure 5. Median and mean equivalized income, survey data (n=188) and annual average in 2023



Moreover, the mean equalized income in Polish cities with populations over 500,000 – where most of the surveys were conducted – was significantly higher, amounting to PLN 5,949 (EUR 1,379). It should be noted, however, that the equivalised income indicator in the Statistics Poland study was calculated using a different formula, so these findings should be interpreted with caution.

Respondents were asked about being able to cover an unexpected expense of EUR 100 (equivalent of about PLN 430 at the time of the survey). While 62 per cent reported being able to afford the expense, 30 per cent said they were not able, and the remaining 8 per cent were not sure or preferred not to answer the question. The average equivalised income of those who were able to afford the unexpected expense was PLN 4,747, or EUR 1100 (PLN 7,346, or EUR 1702, raw disposable income), and those who could not cover the expense had the average equivalised income of PLN 2,592, or EUR 601 (PLN 4,067, or EUR 943 raw disposable income).

REMITTANCES

Among respondents who answered whether their household spent any money in Ukraine in the last 30 days (n=274), 22 per cent reported spending some of their money in Ukraine. Out of those (n=60), 73 per cent reported sending money on a monthly basis.

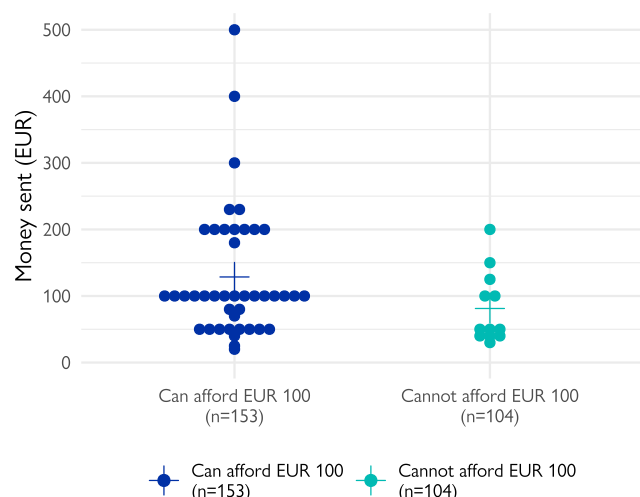
Employment status was found to be a determining factor for the amount sent to Ukraine (including those, who reported spending 0 euros). On average, those employed full-time (46 euros n=132) and self-employed (102, euros n=15) sent significantly higher amounts compared to those who were retired (8 euros, n=21), unemployed and actively seeking work (13 euros, n=12), on maternity or paternity leave (3 euros, n=17), or employed part-time (13 euros, n=25). The amount spent in Ukraine was slightly correlated with equivalised household income, but not with raw disposable income.

The average remittance was associated with the ability to cover an unexpected expense of 100 euros (yes: 53 euros, n=153; no: 9 euros, n=104). Other notable factors influencing the average amount spent in Ukraine included having children (yes: 30 euros, n=167, no: 40 euros, n=107), and plans to eventually return to Ukraine (yes: 40 euros, n=105; no: 22 euros, n=84; undecided: 37 euros, n=85).

2. According to Eurostat, equivalised disposable income is the total income of all household members, after tax and deductions, that is available for spending or saving, divided by the number of household members weighted according to their age. [See here](#) for more information.

3. Statistics Poland, "[Incomes and living conditions of the population in Poland - report from the EU-SILC survey of 2023](#)" (2024), last accessed: 05/08/2024.

Figure 6. Distribution of remittance amounts sent to Ukraine in the last 30 days (in EUR), by respondents' reported ability to afford an unexpected expense of 100 EUR. Average amounts are indicated by crosses.



Persons who did not send anything (199), as well as those who sent more than 500 (3) were not pictured.

The respondents from the South (11%, n=35) and West (14%, n=44) regions of Ukraine were less likely to spend money in their country of origin compared to those from the East (n=111), North (n=37), Center (n=22), and Kyiv (n=25), where spending ranged between 24 and 27 per cent. When examining

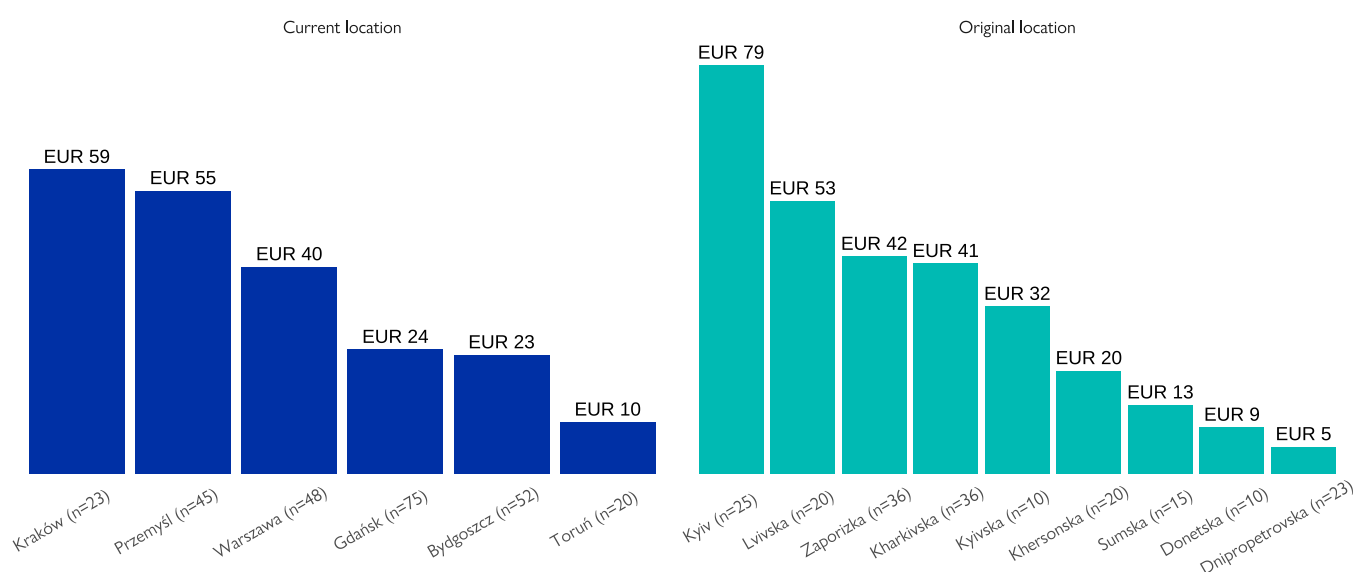
the amounts spent, excluding those who did not spend anything, the largest amounts were reported by respondents from Kyiv (average EUR 331, median EUR 215), while on average those from the North sent the least (EUR 98, median EUR 100). The lowest median was recorded in the Center at EUR 60 (average EUR 153). As a significant number of respondents noted – when asked to elaborate – that the recipients of these transfers are their families in Ukraine, this suggests that at least part of the money is spent in the regions of origin.

Remittance patterns also varied by data collection location. Respondents interviewed in Kraków (n=27) and Przemyśl (n=52) more often reported sending money abroad (35% and 31%, respectively), while those surveyed in Gdańsk (n=80), Bydgoszcz (n=64), Warsaw (n=111), and Toruń (n=22) reported sending money at lower rates (21%, 19%, 17%, and 10%, respectively). Among those who did send remittances, the highest average amount was sent from Warsaw (EUR 241), followed by Przemyśl (EUR 177) and Kraków (EUR 170). Median amounts also reflected this pattern, with Warsaw respondents sending the highest median remittance (EUR 215).

Among those who sent money, there was slight correlation between distance from place of origin and the remittance amount, proving that geographic distance might affect perception of needs. Gender was not a factor in the remittance amount, nor frequency.

Among those who spent money in Ukraine (n=60), 50 per cent sent it to a charity, and 18 per cent spent it on healthcare. Less frequently chosen options included food (7%), clothes (5%), and education (3%).

Figure 7. Amount of money sent to Ukraine in the last 30 days (in EUR), by current location (city in Poland) and place of origin (oblast in Ukraine)



METHODOLOGY

IOM's Displacement Tracking Matrix (DTM) is a system to track and monitor displacement and population mobility. It is designed to regularly and systematically capture, process and disseminate information to provide a better understanding of the movements and evolving needs of displaced populations, whether on site or en route.

The Integration and Social Inclusion Surveys is part of IOM's DTM activities to monitor the profiles and integration process of Ukrainian refugees in Poland. In Poland, surveys were conducted in Ukrainian, Russian, and English by IOM's DTM trained teams of enumerators on a mobile application.

The interviews are anonymous and carried out one-on-one with respondents, provided they consent to be interviewed after a brief introduction. Enumerators trained on ethics of data collection, information provision and protection principles, approached people in various locations across Poland, including collective sites, humanitarian distribution points, transit hubs, public spaces and IOM integration centers, to verify their willingness to conduct the survey, which was only addressed to adults (18+).

The survey form was designed by IOM to capture data on employment situations, economic resilience, social cohesion, access to services, barriers to education, accommodation, and primary needs of refugees from Ukraine following the outbreak of the full-scale war, and it asks about intentions relatively to the permanence in Ukraine. It was developed based on the key integration components outlined in [IOM's Toolkit on Facilitating Pathways to Inclusive and Cohesive Societies](#) (Integration Toolkit), and with indicators largely derived from [IOM/The Immigration Policy Lab's Migration Integration Index](#).

Correlations between ordinal variables (e.g., self-assessed language skills), as well as between ordinal and binary variables (e.g., employment status), were measured using Spearman's rank correlation coefficient or Kendall's rank correlation coefficient. For continuous variables (e.g., composite scores), Pearson's correlation coefficient was used. To test for statistical significance, the default settings of the `cor.test` function from the stats package in R were applied – namely estimating a rank-based measure of association for Spearman's and Kendall's rank correlation, and a *t*-test based on Pearson's product-moment correlation coefficient for Pearson's correlation.

ABOUT THE SURVEY

The aim of the study is to improve understanding of the profiles of refugees from Ukraine residing in Poland, with a focus on their employment situations, economic resilience, social cohesion, and needs. The analysis specifically targets economic inclusion

among this population. Data collection is carried out through face-to-face surveys conducted by 12 trained enumerators at selected locations in Poland, using a mobile application. Interviews are administered in English, Ukrainian, and Russian. This survey is part of a broader regional effort conducted in the second half of 2024 across eight countries hosting refugees from Ukraine, including five neighbouring Ukraine (Hungary, Poland, the Republic of Moldova, Romania, and Slovakia) and three Baltic states (Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania).

LIMITATIONS

Various settings were identified to conduct surveys, to maximise the number of interviews, and reach out to different profiles of individuals. While in border crossing/transit points, such as train stations, the flow of people was higher and interviewees were randomly surveyed (having the same likelihood compared to others to be selected), in other settings, such as collective accommodations and humanitarian aid centres, respondents were intentionally identified. Among the limitations encountered during data collection were the reduced time to carry out surveys at transit points and limited amount of enumerators to cover the desired locations/regions. To address the aforesaid shortcomings, and cover different viewpoints, a mixed sampling strategy guided the data collection exercise. Consequently, this analysis does not proportionally represent the whole population and results cannot be deemed representative of all refugees from Ukraine in Poland, and the results should be considered indicative.

Compared to findings from the Regional Refugee Response for the Ukraine Situation (RRP) Poland Socio-Economic Insights Survey (SEIS), conducted in September 2024, the current sample appears to significantly underrepresent men. According to SEIS, men constitute 24 per cent of the adult Ukrainian refugee population in Poland,⁴ and 33 per cent according to the PESEL UKR registry as of October 2024,⁵ whereas male respondents made up only 7 per cent of the present survey sample.

In terms of age, SEIS indicates that individuals over 60 years old represent 18 per cent of the adult population, suggesting underrepresentation of this group in the current sample, where only 9 per cent of respondents were over 60. The share of respondents caring for infants was disproportionately higher in the sample (19 per cent compared to 6 per cent in SEIS), while only 11 per cent reported having persons over 60 in their household (compared to 23 per cent in SEIS).

These differences between the sample characteristics and SEIS findings should be taken into account when interpreting the results presented in this report.

4. Regional Refugee Response for the Ukraine Situation, "[Poland: Socio-Economic Insights Survey](#)" (2024), last accessed: 05/08/2024.

5. Ministry of Digital Affairs of Poland "[Detailed statistics on persons registered in the register of citizens of Ukraine and members of their families](#)" (2024), last accessed: 05/08/2024.

IOM REGIONAL OFFICE FOR EUROPE AND CENTRAL ASIA

 eca.iom.int

 RegionalDataHubECA@iom.int

Dampfschiffstrasse
4/10-11, 1030
Vienna, Austria

  
[@iomrovienna](https://www.instagram.com/iomrovienna)

DTM

Displacement Tracking Matrix (DTM) is a system to track and monitor displacement and population mobility. The survey form was designed to capture the main displacement patterns – origin country and region – for refugees of any nationality fleeing from Ukraine because of the war. It captures the demographic profiles of respondents and of the group they are travelling with, if any; it asks about intentions relative to the intended destinations and prospects of permanence abroad or return; it gathers information regarding a set of main needs that the respondents expressed as more pressing at the moment of the interview.

Since the onset of the war in Ukraine, several IOM's DTM tools were deployed in countries neighbouring Ukraine and in other countries particularly impacted by the new arrivals of migrants and refugees from Ukraine.

For more information, please consult: <https://dtm.iom.int/responses/ukraine-response>

DTM is part of IOM's Global Data Institute.